Realizing the need for government funding, during General Padmanabhan's tenure as the chief, a case was taken up. 'Mission Olympics' was the name given to the long-term project to rejuvenate sports in the armed forces. Funds were released to create the infrastructure, procure equipment and coaches and give international exposure to our sportsmen. The results began showing from the Commonwealth Games held in Melbourne in 2006. Our performance further improved at the CWG at Delhi, and the at the Guangzhou Asiad. I inaugurated the Army Sports Institute at Pune and gave renewed impetus to Mission Olympics. Disciplines like shooting, boxing, wrestling and rowing received greater attention, as I believed we had better chances in them. I presented the COAS trophies for shooting and golf and had the inaugural tournaments for these games at Mhow and Delhi. It gives me great satisfaction to see these competitions being keenly contested each year.

The 'Catch them young' scheme was introduced by me, wherein the children of armymen were given an opportunity to compete in a few selected disciplines. The children who had the best potential were then given a sports scholarship and trained in Delhi. Their educational needs were also taken care of. A few of them have made a mark at the national level in just three or four years. Unfortunately, this scheme went into cold storage after my tenure, much to the disappointment of all ranks of the army. Soldiers who could not afford the cost of equipment and training of their children with potential in a sport, had some hope because of the 'Catch them young' scheme. In fact, I once went to one of these selection competitions. Young kids with their parents had come from army stations from as far away as Guwahati, Thiruvananthapuram or Jammu and Kashmir. There was so much excitement in the air and a competitive spirit was palpable. In case funds were a problem, I am sure some way could have been found through government or corporate support. If we want to produce world champions, they have to be picked up at the age of ten or twelve years.

Mountaineering has always attracted me. It is true that very few senior officers have trained as mountaineers, and perhaps those who became mountaineers did not rise to high ranks. What greater